to the calf of the leg, twisted and entangled into knots, like the coat of our shaggy dogs . . . several who hold one, and some who hold both arms, perpetually lifted up above the head; the nails of their hands being twisted, and longer than half my little finger'. At first, they remind Bernier of 'the ancient and infamous sect of Cynics', but he only sees in them 'brutality and ignorance' and 'vegetative rather than rational beings'. He rues that 'novices wait upon these fanatics, and pay them the utmost respect, as persons endowed with extraordinary sanctity'.

Bernier has seen 'bands of these naked Fakires, hideous to behold', who 'shamelessly walk, stark naked, through a large town' with 'frightful hair' hung loose or 'twisted round their heads'. He recalls one 'celebrated Fakire, named Sarmet, who paraded the streets of Dehli . . . He despised equally the promises and the threats of Aureng-Zebe, and underwent at length the punishment of decapitation for his obstinate refusal to put on wearing apparel'. The fakirs' public nudity seems to curtail Bernier's sympathy for them, though he is also disgusted by what he sees as their ignorance, superstition and lack of piety, evident in their painful austerities and fasting for days in order to seek union with God.

Piety mattered to Bernier because he was also a proud Christian and shared the historical European antipathy towards Islam. From his account, it's clear that he favours the 'establishment of missions, and the sending forth of learned and pious missionaries'. 'They are absolutely necessary,' he says. Christians ought to 'supply every part of the world with men bearing the same character and following the same benign object as did the Apostles . . . promoting the glory of their REDEEMER'. Bernier expects some Gentiles to convert, but about Muslims he says, 'It is in vain to hope, however, that they will renounce the religion wherein they were born, or be persuaded that Mahomet was a false prophet . . . To counteract [Islam's] baneful progress, Christians must display the zeal.'

Bernier also had many discourses with Gentile scholars, including 'the six most learned Pendets' of Varanasi, but nothing seems to have impressed him. He concedes that some of their hypotheses 'have an affinity to the theories of Democritus and Epicurus', but he claims their 'opinions are expressed in so loose and indeterminate a manner that it is difficult to ascertain their meaning'. This leads him to think that 'the Pendets neither comprehend themselves, nor can make [themselves] intelligible to others'.